

3, The Fascinating Event That Birthed These 400,000 Words

As always, I must express my profound gratitude to my friend H. Although we no longer live in the same city, he has consistently offered me enthusiastic and exceptionally acute assistance.

During the six months starting from October 2023, my friend B—whom I have known since elementary school—gradually came to understand and embrace my perspectives, as we are both currently at Xi'an Jiaotong University and have the opportunity to meet weekly. He subsequently became my right-hand man when compiling these materials. He could always offer suggestions from myriad angles I hadn't considered, granting me tremendous inspiration and fortifying my resolve to complete this marathon of a task.

Although my friend A and I have not attended the same school since graduating high school, this has in no way diminished our relationship and interactions. Over the past two years, our mutual influence has never ceased. My concepts inspired him to march steadfastly down his academic path. Furthermore, as a Hui person (回族人), he completely discarded the various commandments of Islam and unhesitatingly defends modern life! To me, A is a role model who dares to think and dares to act. He inspired me to courageously express my views (*though in this society, one must obviously mind one's safety*) and not allow the achievements I have already made to vanish down the drain.

S and I met in junior high school. For a long time, we were merely casual friends. In early 2023, S learned from me about the definite results I had already achieved. During the summer vacation that year, S made the decision to emigrate to Canada—for the Chinese have always proclaimed, "*A gentleman does not stand under a collapsing wall*" (君子不立危墙之下). He also believed it was absolutely necessary for me to organize and expand my previously scattered notes into a complete, unified narrative. At the time, however, I consistently felt the timing was premature, as my observations regarding the rest of the world were still severely lacking.

It wasn't until the high summer of 2024, when we met on the afternoon of August 20th, that S brought this matter up again. At that moment, we were buying food at a street-side hotdog stand. Suddenly, black clouds swept in from the west. Within moments, the surroundings grew as dim as eight or nine o'clock at night. As we sat beneath a parasol waiting for our hotdogs, the distant lightning had now migrated directly above our heads. We chatted about our views on the current political situation, watching the world before our eyes be illuminated for a split second, only for the light to be swiftly annihilated by darkness.

Just as a torrential downpour unleashed itself, we finally received our ordered hotdogs. Fortunately, the wind was not ferocious. Thus, the two of us ate this simple dinner accompanied by the symphony of thunder, the roar of the rain, and the flashing brilliance of lightning.

Filled with profound emotion, I said to S: *"Ever since the dawn of humanity, thunderstorms have been one of the most magnificent natural phenomena our ancestors could observe. In modern Chinese, the character '奄' (Yan) originally depicted, in Oracle Bone Script, a person standing beneath a bolt of lightning. Today, it can be deconstructed into the characters '大' (great/person) and '电' (lightning).*

When the ancients saw black clouds covering the wilderness and lightning cleaving the earth, the character '奄' acquired the meaning of 'covering' and 'possessing.' Hence, we have those

staggeringly heroic expressions like 'To exclusively possess the realm of Xia' (奄有区夏) or 'To entirely encompass the Four Seas' (奄有四海)!

Yet, humanity's pursuit of the direction of social development is exactly like travelers in a boundless desert trying to discern the right path—how agonizingly difficult it is! They might sink into quicksand, be plundered by bandits, be trapped by a scarcity of supplies, or become mesmerized by the mirages of false utopias. With every stretch traveled, the number of people who can reach the next oasis dwindles.

Success or failure cannot be known in a single moment, yet one must meticulously observe. Conquering vast territories does not necessarily guarantee progress, just as small states are not necessarily incapable of achieving monumental feats!"

Our conversation then drifted elsewhere, and I can no longer recall exactly what was said. By the time I finished speaking, I had already consumed one hotdog. I utilized the rainwater cascading from the edge of the parasol to wash my hands and absentmindedly scrubbed my face. S, having finished his portion, was persuaded by me to wash up in the same manner. Evidently, we were both immensely satisfied with this primal experience.

We sat in silence for about ten minutes. The wind drove the darkness eastward; the clouds dissipated, and the rain ceased. The enduring brilliance of the sun replaced the ephemeral flashes of lightning, and the chirping of birds replaced the roar of thunder.

We sat and chatted for another half hour. I then escorted S to the subway station, and he took the high-speed rail back to Beijing.

In truth, even up to the end of that conversation, I never explicitly stated that I would write these matters down. But deep within the recesses of my heart, I had already made the decision.

The strength of any single individual is inevitably limited. **Yet, I am determined to light a candle, to finally behold the full panorama of this elephant that has hidden in the darkness for thousands of years.** Today, what I can achieve is nothing more than the flickering illumination of a candle in the night (炳烛之明); but the day will come when radiant light shall bathe the entire world!

3, 导致这四十万字诞生的有趣事件

我要一如既往感谢我的朋友 H，虽然我们现在不在一个城市生活，但是他总是热情并且十分敏锐地对我提供帮助。在 2023 年 10 月开始的半年里，我和在小学时候就已经结识的朋友 B 逐渐了解并且接纳了我的观点，因为我们现在都在西安交大，每周都有机会碰面。随后他成为我整理这些资料时的得力助手，总能从各种我没有考虑到的方面提供建议给我很大的启发，也坚定了完成这一漫长工作的决心。朋友 A 虽然在高中毕业之后和我就一直不在一个学校，但是这并没有影响我们之间的关系和互动。在过去两年中这种双向的影响并没有停歇，我的观念鼓舞他在学术道路上坚定地走下去，并且作为一个回族人完全抛弃了穆斯林的种种戒律，毫不迟疑地捍卫现代生活。A 对我来说是一个敢想敢做的榜样，他鼓舞我勇敢表达自己的观点（当然在这个社会必须注意安全），不要让已经取得的成果付诸东流。

S 和我在初中的时候相识，在很长时间内我们都只作为一般朋友，23 年初的时候，S 从我这里获知了当时已经取得的一定成果。在当年暑假的时候，S 就决定移民到加拿大，因为中国人向来声称“君子不立危墙之下”，并且认为我有必要将之前分散的记录整理并扩充成一个完整的叙事，不过那个时候我还一直认为时机不成熟，对于世界其他地方的观察还缺得太多。直到 2024 年的盛夏，我们在 8 月 20 日下午见面的时候 S 又说起这件事，当时我们正在一家街边的热狗摊买热狗吃。忽然乌云从西方席卷而来，不消片刻四周就已经像晚上八、九点钟一样昏暗，在我们坐在遮阳伞下等热狗的时候，远方的闪电现在移动到了头顶上，我们一边聊着对于当下局势的看法，一边看着眼前的世界偶尔被照亮一秒，然后光明

迅速湮灭。就在阵雨倾盆而下的时候，我们终于取到了点的热狗，所幸风并不大，于是两人便就着雷声、雨声以及闪电的光芒吃了这顿简易的晚餐。

当时我不无感慨地对 S 说，自从人类诞生以来，电闪雷鸣就是我们的祖先所能观察到的最壮丽的自然现象之一。现代汉语中的“奄”字，其在甲骨文中原本就是闪电下的一个人，在今天可以拆成“大”“电”两个字。古人看到乌云覆盖原野，闪电劈向大地，“奄”字就有了覆盖和占有的含义，所以就有了“奄有区夏”“奄有四海”这样豪情万丈的表述。只是人们追寻社会发展的方向，就如同茫茫大漠中的旅人辨明道路一般，多么艰难啊！或者陷入流沙，或者为歹人所劫，或困于补给匮乏，或耽于海市蜃楼的愿景，每走一段，能够到达下一个绿洲的人就会少一些。成败非一时可知，却不可不明察，征服广大的疆土不一定带来进步，小国也未必不能成大业。尔后又延伸到了别处，现在也记不清说了什么，言毕一根热狗已被我吃完。于是我借着从遮阳伞的边缘流下的水流洗了手，顺便还搓了把脸，S 在吃完他的那份之后与我的劝说下也这样清洗完毕，显然我们都对这种体验非常满意。我们又静静坐了大概十分钟，风将黑暗向东驱赶，云销雨霁，太阳持续的光明取代了须臾的闪电光辉，鸟鸣声取代了雷声。我们又坐着聊了半个小时，我把 S 送到地铁站，他便乘高铁回北京去了。实际上，直到那次谈话我并没有明确说我会把这些事情写下来，但是我内心深处已经做好了这个决定。每个人的力量都是有限的，但是我仍然要点燃一根蜡烛，看一看这头在黑暗中隐藏了数千年的大象的全貌。今天我能实现的不过是炳烛之明，来日光亮将洒满世间。